

“PERIPHERALS ARE REFLECTORS OF ONE’S PERSONALITY”



Microsoft Hardware, one of the leaders in PC peripherals, has been aggressively pushing its latest products in the market. In October 2008, the company launched nine products that married high-end technology and fashion.

Ashim Mathur, national marketing manager, Entertainment and Devices Division, Microsoft Corporation (India), speaks to Uma Bansal of EFY about their plans for 2009, new products/technologies launched and also how the company is viewing the growing markets in the country. Excerpts:

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In these times of recession, how has been the year 2008 for Microsoft Hardware in India?

We are not immune to the effects of the economy. Consumers and businesses have reined in spending, which is affecting PC shipments and IT expenditures. But in India we have a great opportunity in tier-2 and tier-3 towns. Consumers and small business have recognised the importance of computing and the production of low-cost netbooks/PCs and a stable growth of retail in India will fuel the industry.

What are the new products launched in India?

In October 2008, Microsoft Hardware launched a slew of nine extremely stylish products. These will be the flagship products for the company in 2009. The newly launched products are a blend of style and science. These not only feature the best technology but also are some of the most beautiful computer peripherals around.

Considering that Indian buyers give more weightage to price than features, how was the response to this product range?

The response that we got from the consumers has been overwhelming. Today, peripherals are not mere extensions of computers, these are reflectors of one's personality. A lot of research goes into the needs and the tastes of the consumers on the basis of which we develop the products.

Products such as the Explorer Mini Mouse that features the revolutionary BlueTrack technology (enabling it to track on over 40 different surfaces), the slim and stylish Arc Mouse (which can be folded to 50 per cent of its size for portability) and the LifeCam Show (world's thinnest webcam) have proved to become very popular.

Who have been the main customers of these products so far?

Though a small market in comparison to the huge PC industry, over the years the market demand for computer peripherals has been increasing due to larger consumption

of technology. This is especially the case for tier-2 and tier-3 cities that has seen a spurt in the purchase of computers, subsequently resulting in an increase in the sales of peripherals.

How do you plan to extend the market?

A channel partner plays an important role in the sales and marketing of Microsoft Hardware products due to their proximity to the customer. By educating them, Microsoft Hardware hopes to enlighten these dealers about Microsoft Hardware's latest products.

We have several campaigns like the Discover India Yatra and more recently the channel initiative in 25 cities across India.

In year 2009, how do you see the market for PC peripherals in India?

Computer peripherals are gradually transforming to become a trendy and stylish segment. These are no longer looked upon as equipment to aid your work on the PC. Nowadays, users recognise them as personality reflectors.

The growth in the market will be more in tier-2 and tier-3 cities as the purchasing power in these cities has greatly increased. Therefore newer business opportunities will result in newer tieups. In an effort to attract retailers in these markets, companies will size up their marketing strategies and plans to reach out to them as effectively as possible.

Your advice to PC peripheral buyers?

Computers are now a necessary part of our lives and peripheral accessories like mice and keyboard are important determinants of healthy computing. Buyers are recommended to consider technology and ergonomics of the products they are investing in as it goes a long way in leading a healthy computing lifestyle. Also, as an extension of your personality, today computer accessories and gadgets reflect your personality. Go for something that complements your style and is also high on technology.